a bold contrast. “The natural sodium in Spain’s Vichy Catalan creates a brilliant counterpoint to a chocolate mousse.”

The extremes of the water world also serve functional roles. Hungary’s Hunyadi János is so salty (TDS of 30,200) that it nearly tastes like seawater and been used to tackle inflammation and bloating. “You’d actually spit it out on its own,” notes Mehta, “but pair it with a piece of goat cheese and it tastes remarkable.” Meanwhile, Slovenia’s ROI sourced from underground springs contains approximately 1300 mg of magnesium per litre. Because magnesium is a critical electrolyte depleted by alcohol, a single ‘shot’ of ROI after a night of heavy drinking can help to recover from a hangover.

BEVERAGE

TREND



WHY WATER CAN COST MORE THAN WINE

What justifies a five-figure price tag for a bottle of water? According to Iyer, it’s the uniqueness of the origin and the complexity of procurement that dictates the price. “Sometimes, the source could be 4,000 years old. Take Svalbarði (₹10,800 per 750ml), which requires a 15-day Arctic expedition to harvest specific icebergs in Norway’s remote fjords.” Similarly, Ô Amazon Air Water (₹11,000 (per 750ml) captures moisture directly from the Amazon. Because the water never touches the ground, it maintains an exceptionally low TDS (Total Dissolved Solids). In Hawaii, Kona Deep is desalinated and bottled from 3,000 feet below the ocean surface. However, the primary price driver is the journey from source to table. “For premium waters, 90% of the cost is logistics. Because brands like Svalbarði must be bottled at their singular, protected origin before global shipping, the supply chain is as rare as the liquid itself,” says Mehta. Ultimately, the premium isn’t for hydration; it is for the infrastructure required to deliver an untouched piece of the natural world.



Svalbarði polar iceberg water (Top right); The water trolley at The Inn at Little Washington (Bottlom right)

In the upper echelons of hydration, water is a collector’s item. The most expensive, Acqua di Cristallo Tributo a Modigliani, is a ₹50 lakh ($60,000) 24-carat gold vessel containing a blend of Icelandic, Fijian and French springs infused with 23-carat gold dust. Other ultra-luxury staples include Japan’s Swarovski-encrusted Fillico Jewelry Water (₹1.15 lakh/litre) and the crystal-clad Hollywood favourite, Bling H_2O (₹2.2 lakh).

This appetite for high-end hydration has firmly landed in India. As early as 2018, Malaki introduced 24K gold-flake water at ₹899 (330ml), while Finland’s VEEN, sourced from Bhutanese aquifers, has become a staple at 5-star hotels and high-end restaurants across India. At Food Stories gourmet stores, sales of premium water tripled in 2025. According to co-founder Avni Biyani, the chain recently imported the light and creamy Saratoga Spring Water from New York. Despite a price tag of ₹799 for a 355ml bottle, the stock sold out within days.

As the last drop of the 4,000-year-old ice melts away in my glass, it becomes clear that we are no longer just drinking to quench our thirst. We are drinking to taste a moment in time, a connection to the wild.